

NIGERIA'S N-POWER PROGRAMME

Origin, Performance, and Reform Options, 2016 to 2026

A ten year Active Labour Market Programme reviewed across its origin, its performance, its data quality, and its reform options.

500K

PEOPLE THE
PROGRAMME
SAID IT REACHED

90K

DOCUMENTED
FALSE NAMES ON
PAYROLL

14.5%

EFFECT SIZE IN
THE ONE IMPACT
STUDY
CONDUCTED

1/10

FRACTION OF
THE 2016
STIPEND VALUE
THE PAYMENT
NOW HOLDS

This summary distills a 43 page independent monitoring and evaluation review of Nigeria's N-Power Programme across its full ten year arc. The review draws on **a curated 30 source evidence matrix** spanning official government documents, legislative texts, World Bank appraisal material, peer reviewed evaluations, investigative journalism, anti corruption findings, and civil society reporting. The review is a **secondary analysis** based entirely on public sources. Where sources conflict, contradictions are named openly rather than reconciled.

FIVE FINDINGS

The five findings of the review

Each finding is stated at the strength the evidence supports. The full working sits in the main brief.

FINDING 1, ORIGIN

A rapid consolidation without inherited accountability

N-Power was launched on 8 June 2016 under the National Social Investment Office as a consolidation and tenfold scale up of the 2012 to 2015 SURE-P Graduate Internship Scheme, answering the APC 2015 manifesto pledge to scrap that "corruption ridden" scheme, against the backdrop of Nigeria's first full year recession in a generation. GDP contracted 0.67%, 1.49% and 2.34% across the first three quarters of 2016; youth (15 to 35) unemployment and underemployment reached **52.65% (22.64 million people)** by Q3 2017. The parallel US\$500 million World Bank credit did not fund N-Power; the programme sat in the government's own contribution and therefore **never inherited the donor built verification architecture**: output based disbursement, independent ex post verification, a published scorecard, or an impact evaluation plan. The architecture was borrowed. The accountability apparatus was not.

FINDING 2, PURPOSE THEN AND NOW

A rebrand of the same programme

The 2016 purpose was a two year, **₦30,000 per month** public service deployment for 500,000 young Nigerians, stated in four objectives mixing individual livelihood support with systemic public service repair. The 2025 to 2026 "Renewed Hope" framing renames the programme, halves the duration to one year without a published rationale, and circulates a five million beneficiary target with no costed framework. The stipend, the absence of a results framework, and the deployment logic remain unchanged. **The instrument is the same. The problem it was designed for has changed.**

FINDING 3, PERFORMANCE

Enrolments are counted, verification is thin

Official reach claims (500,000 across Batches A and B; 900,000 N-Teach and 150,000 N-Health cumulative deployments) are broadly consistent across official and journalistic sources, but the payroll was found contaminated. Anti corruption and investigative reporting documents **70,000 ghost names over four years plus a further 20,000** on a second list, up to 90,000 payroll ghost names, roughly **9 to 18% of claimed reach** depending on the denominator used. On outcomes the record is thinner still: the only published impact study, a cross sectional survey of 99 Lagos beneficiaries, finds a statistically significant but modest positive effect ($R^2 = 0.145$), with 41.4% of its sample still unemployed and only 7.1% in wage employment. **No national post exit tracer study, no randomized or quasi experimental evaluation, and no cost effectiveness calculation has ever been conducted for N-Power in ten years.**

FINDING 4, STIPEND EROSION

The stipend has silently lost purchasing power

The **₦30,000 monthly stipend** was set in 2016 and held nominally constant through 2026, with no indexation mechanism written into the design. Over the same window, food inflation ran at 26.08% year on year in January 2025, 21.14% in May 2025, and 14.31% in March 2026. Deflated by the NBS Food CPI, the 2016 stipend retains an estimated **₦3,000 to ₦5,000** of its original purchasing power in 2026, roughly one sixth to one tenth of its launch value. Restoring the 2016 real value would require a 2026 stipend of **₦180,000 to ₦300,000 per month**, six to ten times higher than the current rate. **The companion World Bank financed design contained an automatic CPI adjustment principle as binding doctrine. The domestically financed N-Power stipend omitted it.** The absence of an indexation rule was a design choice.

FINDING 5, THE REFORM QUESTION

The reset has not fixed the earlier design gaps

The January 2024 suspension, promised for six weeks, in the event lasted **roughly 12.5 months**. It was not followed by published Panel findings. **Over ₦30 billion** recovered from the GEEP and GVG streams was traced and frozen but not remitted to the Treasury Single Account, leaving programmes unable to fully resume. The Renewed Hope reset's documented changes are a rename, a silent halving of duration, an unindexed stipend, and a verification gate on old arrears. The absent core, a published results framework, an indexation mechanism, a post exit tracer, is exactly what would make the reset structural. **The reset is attempting to build, at the point of the arrears, the identity verification system the 2016 design named as foundational and never built at scale.**

₦186bn

NSIP ALLOCATED 2016, N-POWER SPECIFIC VERIFIED IN ONLY ONE MONTH

17 months

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL TO NON RESUMPTION GAP (WITH HGSE, BRIEF 3)

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NATIONAL TRACER STUDIES OF N-POWER BENEFICIARIES AT EXIT

WHAT THE FINDINGS SHOW TOGETHER

Together the findings describe a programme that was politically durable across two administrations of different parties, that retains a modest and empirically documented positive effect on participants alongside a sobering raw employment picture in its only measured sample, and that **lacked the basic monitoring infrastructure** across its full ten year history: a public dashboard, a tracer methodology, an indexation rule, and a biometric identity link. This absence of infrastructure sits at the centre of the review's concern.

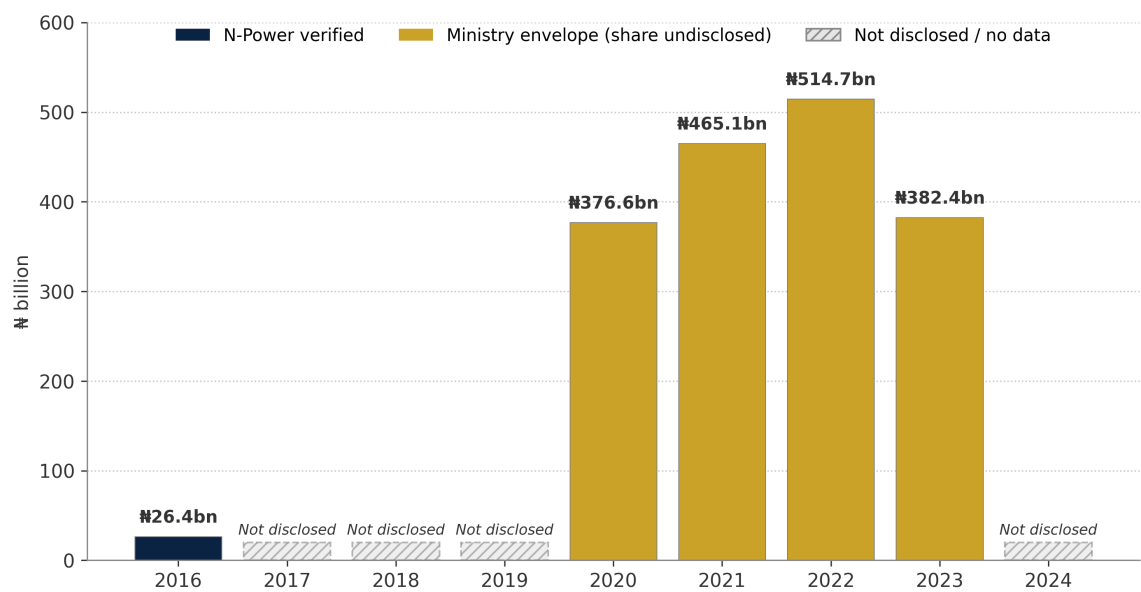
SECTION 3.2, FISCAL RECORD

The public record of N-Power spending

Across nine programme years, only one N-Power specific spending figure exists in the public record. Four years show ministry envelopes where the N-Power share is undisclosed. Four years show no disclosed figure at all.

What can and cannot be known about N-Power spending, 2016-2024

Only one N-Power-specific figure exists in the public record. All others are ministry envelopes or missing entirely.



Sources: TheCable (2019, 2021) for 2016; BudgIT tracker (2020–2023) for ministry-level FMHDMSD envelopes. N-Power share of ministry envelopes is not publicly disclosed. 2017–2019 and 2024 have no disclosed N-Power figure. The empty bars are the finding.

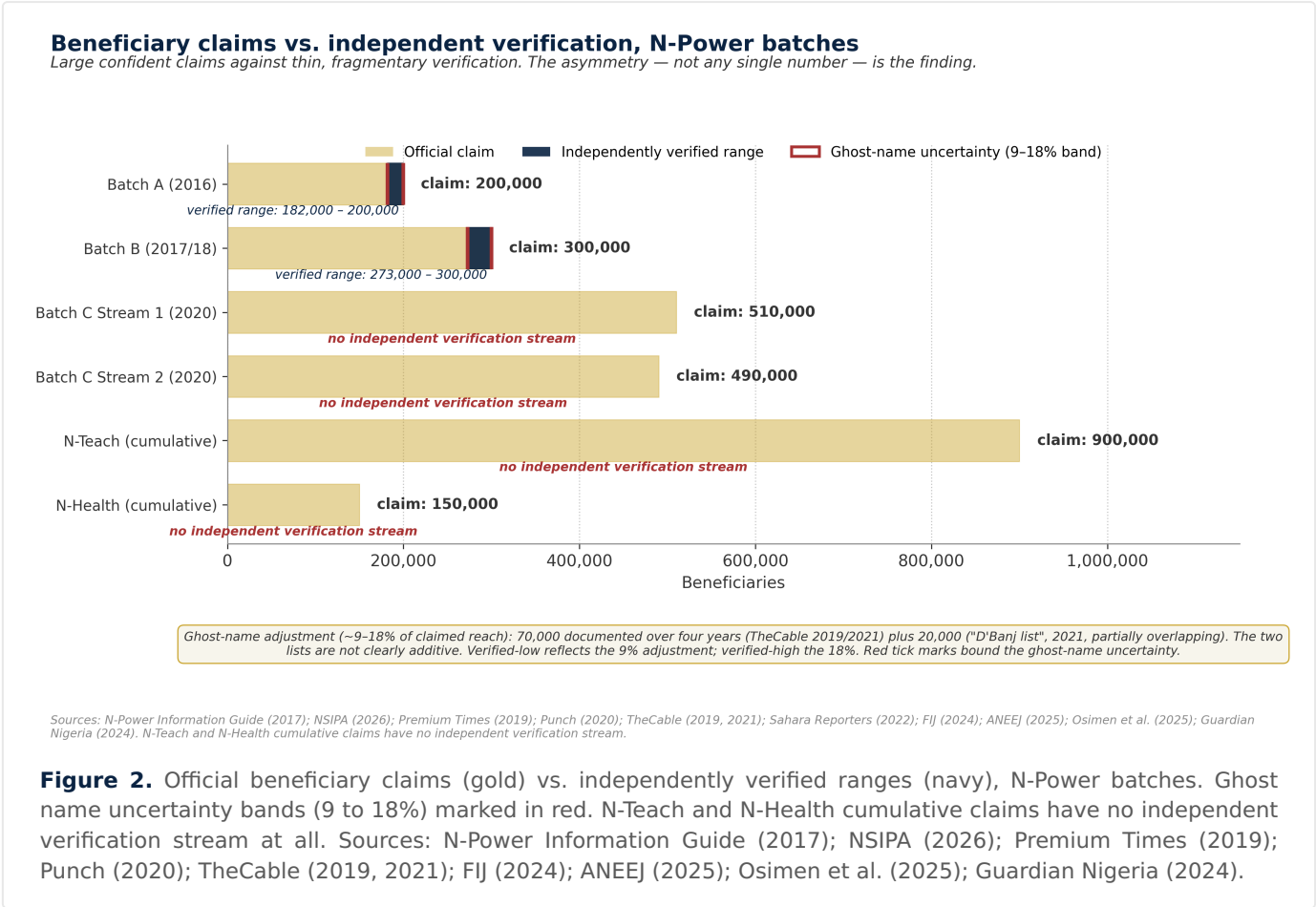
Figure 1. Federal budget allocation and disbursement, N-Power specific vs. ministry envelope, 2016 to 2024. Only 2016 has a verified N-Power specific figure (₦26.4bn). The 2020 to 2023 bars show ministry level FMHDMSD envelopes; N-Power's share within them is not publicly disclosed. Four years (2017 to 2019, 2024) have no disclosed figure. Sources: TheCable (2019, 2021); BudgIT tracker (2020 to 2023).

YEAR	ALLOCATED (₦BN)	DATA STATUS
2016	500.0 (NSIP total)	N-Power specific share: ~₦26.4bn by May 2016 (verified anchor)
2017 to 2019	Not disclosed	No N-Power specific fiscal figure in the public record
2020	376.6	FMHDMSD ministry envelope; N-Power share undisclosed
2021	465.1	FMHDMSD ministry envelope, +23.5% y/y
2022	514.7	FMHDMSD ministry envelope, +10.7% y/y
2023	382.4	FMHDMSD ministry envelope, -25.7% y/y
2024	Suspended	Programme suspended January 2024

SECTION 3.4, CLAIMS VS VERIFICATION

Reach claims and independent verification compared

The gap between what the programme claimed and what the record independently verifies is the substance of this section.



BATCH OR STRAND	OFFICIAL CLAIM	VERIFICATION STATUS
Batch A (2016)	200,000	Consistent across official and press records, not audited. Verified range 182,000 to 200,000.
Batch B (2017 to 2018)	300,000	Broadly corroborated, not audited. Verified range 273,000 to 300,000.
Batch C Stream 1 (2020)	~510,000	Inauguration reported, full deployment unverified.
Batch C Stream 2 (2020)	~490,000	No completion record. #108bn arrears to 400,000 beneficiaries (Jul 2024).
N-Teach (cumulative)	900,000	No independent verification stream.
N-Health (cumulative)	150,000	No independent verification stream.

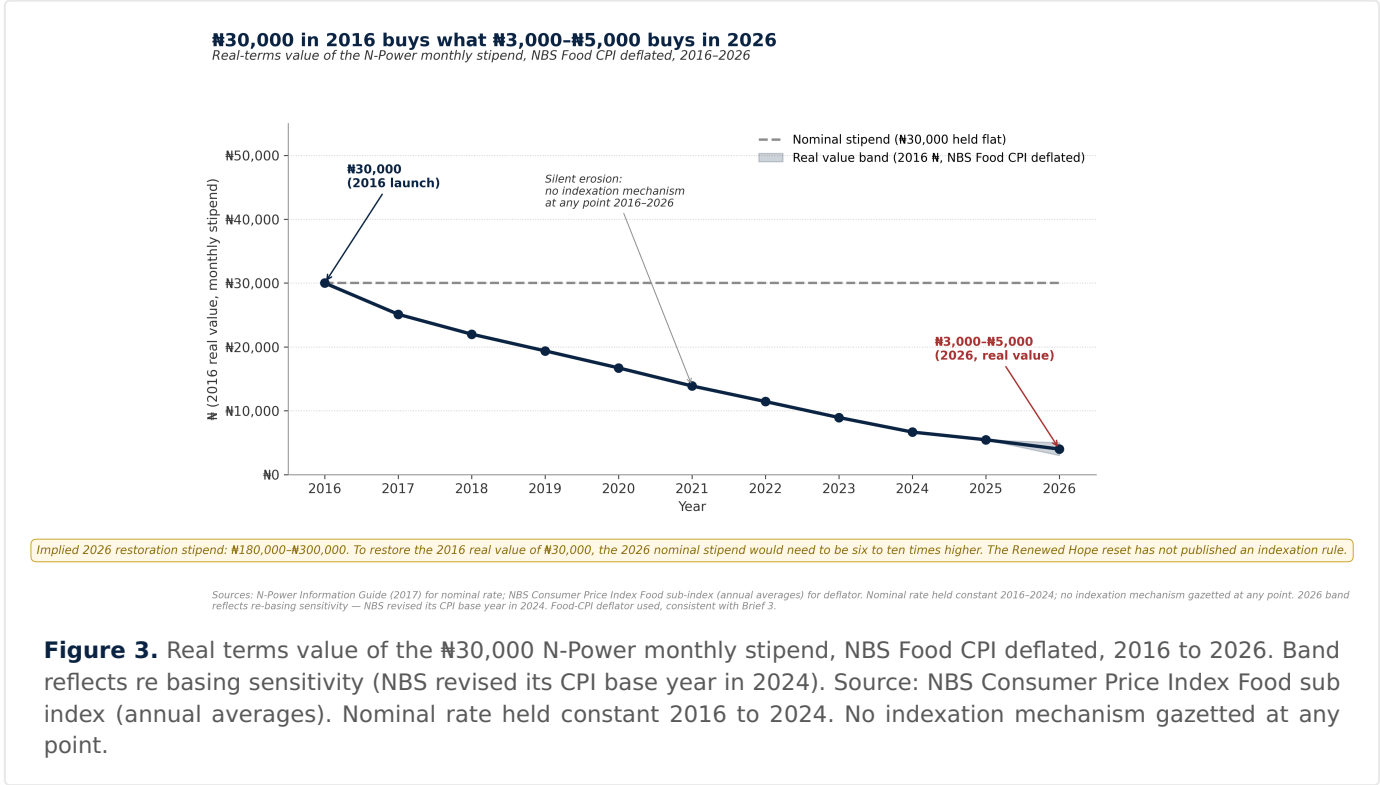
GHOST NAME ADJUSTMENT

70,000 ghost names documented over four years (TheCable 2019 and 2021), plus 20,000 on a second list ("D'Banj list", 2021, partially overlapping). The two lists are not clearly additive. The 9% figure assumes full overlap; the 18% assumes no overlap. The true value is bounded but not known precisely.

SECTION 4.5, REAL VALUE DECAY

The real value of the ₦30,000 stipend

The stipend has been buying less every year without any budget decision to that effect.



DATA POINT	VALUE	NOTE
Nominal stipend 2016 to 2026	₦30,000 (flat, unindexed)	Verified from N-Power Information Guide (2017) and NSIPA (2026)
Food inflation, Jan 2025 (YoY)	26.08%	NBS 2026
Food inflation, May 2025 (YoY)	21.14%	NBS 2026
Food inflation, Mar 2026 (YoY)	14.31%	NBS 2026
Retained real value by 2026	₦3,000 to ₦5,000 (~1/6 to 1/10 of launch)	Derived band, food CPI deflator
Implied restoration stipend	₦180,000 to ₦300,000 per month	Six to ten times the current nominal rate

TEN RECOMMENDATIONS, TWO PRECONDITIONS

The recommended reforms and preconditions

Each recommendation names the responsible actor, the instrument, and the timeframe. Two structural preconditions apply before the ten recommendations can be operationalised.

PRECONDITION P1

Biometric NSR to NIMC link

The 2016 design named this identity verification system as foundational. It was never built at scale. Every reform below assumes it exists. Actor: NSIPA with NIMC. Instrument: Memorandum of Understanding. Timeframe: pilot 10,000 beneficiaries across two states within 180 days.

PRECONDITION P2

Remit recovered ₦30bn to the Treasury Single Account

Funds recovered from the GEEP and GVG streams remain traced and frozen, not released. No downstream reform is credible while the recovered sum sits outside the TSA. Actor: Office of the Accountant General with EFCC. Instrument: TSA remittance order. Timeframe: 90 days.

R1

LEGISLATE AUTOMATIC STIPEND INDEXATION

A reviewed stipend rate must be submitted to the National Assembly within 60 days whenever NBS Food CPI exceeds 25% growth from the preceding review baseline.

Actor: National Assembly | **Instrument:** 2026 Finance Act clause | **Target:** Pass in 2026 appropriation cycle

R2

MANDATE A POST EXIT TRACER STUDY

Every exiting batch must be followed by a tracer survey at 6, 12, and 24 months, with results published on a public NSIPA dashboard.

Actor: NSIPA with an accredited Nigerian research institution | **Instrument:** Ring fenced 1% of programme budget | **Target:** First tracer within 12 months of next batch exit

R3

PUBLISH A PUBLIC RESULTS FRAMEWORK BEFORE NEXT ENROLMENT

No new batch onboarding until a costed logframe with indicators at input, output, outcome, and impact levels is publicly gazetted and archived.

Actor: NSIPA with Federal Ministry of Budget and National Planning | **Instrument:** Ministerial gazette | **Target:** 90 days

R4

PUBLIC QUARTERLY DASHBOARD

Batch, state, and LGA level beneficiary counts and disbursement figures published within 30 days of each quarter end. BudgIT and NEDI templates already exist.

Actor: NSIPA with FME | **Instrument:** Existing NEDI platform | **Target:** Dashboard live in 90 days

R5

INDEPENDENT THIRD PARTY VERIFICATION BUDGET LINE

Ring fence at least 1% of the annual N-Power budget for accredited Nigerian CSO verification. At a ₦100bn programme, that is ₦1bn, less than a single documented fraud incident.

Actor: Federal Ministry of Finance with NSIPA | **Instrument:** 2027 appropriation line | **Target:** Include in 2027 budget cycle

R6**OUTCOME-LEVEL REPORTING MANDATE**

Every quarterly report must include at least one outcome indicator, not only output indicators. Time to first employment, earnings gain, and formal vs informal employment share are the priority three.

Actor: NSIPA | **Instrument:** Reporting template revision | **Target:** Q1 2027 reporting cycle

R7**FREEDOM OF INFORMATION RESPONSE STANDARD**

NSIPA to publish a public FOI response ledger with request date, subject, response date, and outcome. Non response beyond the statutory seven day window flagged automatically.

Actor: NSIPA | **Instrument:** FOIA compliance protocol | **Target:** Ledger live in 60 days

R8**BENEFICIARY FEEDBACK MECHANISM**

Kobo-based grievance and feedback collection at deployment sites, with quarterly aggregate reporting. Anonymity protected. Retaliation prohibited by clause.

Actor: NSIPA with NEDI | **Instrument:** Standard Operating Procedure | **Target:** Pilot in 3 states within 120 days

R9**EX-BENEFICIARY VOICE ARCHIVE**

Curated qualitative testimony from ex-beneficiaries at 6, 12, and 24 month intervals, with respondent identity protected through cell suppression. Published alongside tracer statistics.

Actor: Accredited Nigerian research institution | **Instrument:** Standing research contract | **Target:** First cohort published by end 2027

R10**PUBLIC CONSULTATION BEFORE BATCH LAUNCH**

No new batch enrolment until a structured public consultation with State Ministries of Labour, civil society, and youth representatives is documented and published.

Actor: NSIPA with State MoLs | **Instrument:** Pre-enrolment consultation protocol | **Target:** Before Batch D or equivalent

Read the full brief

These recommendations and the underlying analysis are drawn from a 43 page independent monitoring and evaluation review. The full brief includes the complete 30 source evidence matrix, theory of change measurement coverage table, contradictions register, standards compliance audit, the full theory of change reconstruction, and the complete methodological note supporting the ten recommendations and two preconditions summarised here.

github.com/Almuarif17/social-protection-me-nigeria | **Brief 4 of the Independent M&E Reviews of Nigerian Social Investment Programmes**